

5K Running Training Plan

24-Week Beginner Program

Race Distance: 5 kilometers (3.1 miles)

Target Audience: Complete beginners with no running experience

Prerequisites: Basic fitness level (able to walk 30 minutes)

Weekly Training: 3-4 days per week | 2-4 hours total

Program Structure: 6 phases with extended base building and gradual progression

Program Overview

This 24-week extended beginner program takes you from zero to 5K race ready with ample time for adaptation. The plan uses a run/walk approach with a longer base-building phase, allowing your body to adapt safely to running. By race day, you'll be confident running the full 5K distance.

Key Principles:

- Gradual progression with extended base building
 - Run/walk intervals transition slowly to continuous running
 - 3-4 training days per week with adequate recovery
 - Progressive volume increases (no more than 10% per week)
 - Injury prevention through proper technique and recovery
 - Flexibility to adjust based on individual response
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PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Weeks 1-6)

Week 1: Introduction to Running

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk Introduction (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 1 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 1 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (30 min)

- Entire session conversational pace

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~1.5 hours

Week 2-3: Build Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (35 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

Week 4: Extend Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 3 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 3 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (40 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

Week 5: Longer Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 4 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 4 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (45 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 6: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~1.5 hours

PHASE 2: BUILDING ENDURANCE (Weeks 7-12)

Week 7-8: Extend Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 5 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 3 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 5 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 3 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (45 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 9: Longer Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 7 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 2 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 7 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 2 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (50 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 10: Extended Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min running, 2 min walking, 10 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min running, 2 min walking, 10 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (50 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 11-12: Recovery Weeks

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 8 min running, 2 min walking, 8 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 8 min running, 2 min walking, 8 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (40 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

PHASE 3: TRANSITION TO CONTINUOUS RUNNING

(Weeks 13-18)

Week 13-14: First Continuous 5K Attempts

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 15: Build to 5K Distance

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min continuous easy running (approximately 5K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 16-18: Consistent 5K Running

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk

- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

PHASE 4: RACE SIMULATION (Weeks 19-21)

Week 19-20: Race Pace Introduction

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 21: Peak Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

PHASE 5: FINAL PREPARATION (Weeks 22-23)

Week 22: Begin Taper

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

Week 23: Taper Continues

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk

- Main Set: 15 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Easy Run (15 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Saturday: Rest day

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~1 hour

PHASE 6: RACE WEEK (Week 24)

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (15 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Rest day - Final preparations

- Lay out all gear
- Review race course

- Early bed time

Sunday: RACE DAY!

- Arrive 30 min early
- Warm up gently with 5 min walk + 5 min easy jog
- Trust your 24 weeks of training
- Have fun and enjoy the experience!

Weekly Volume: ~0.5 hours

Running Pacing Guidelines

Easy Pace: You should be able to hold a conversation comfortably. This is your primary training pace.

Conversational Pace: Similar to easy pace, used for longer runs and recovery sessions.

Race Pace: The pace you plan to run the 5K. You can speak in short sentences but not full conversations.

Nutrition for Running

Pre-Run (1-2 hours before):

- Banana with almond butter
- Toast with jam
- Rice cakes with honey
- Small bowl of oatmeal

During Run (sessions >45 min):

- Water with electrolytes
- Sports drink if available

Post-Run (within 30 min):

- Protein + carbs (chicken with rice, protein smoothie, turkey sandwich)
 - Rehydrate with water or electrolyte drink
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Injury Prevention

Warm-up: Always start with 5 minutes of easy walking before running.

Cool-down: Always end with 5 minutes of easy walking after running.

Stretching: Stretch for 10-15 minutes after each run, focusing on calves, hamstrings, quads, and hip flexors.

Rest Days: Take at least 2-3 complete rest days per week. Your body adapts during rest, not during training.

Listen to Your Body: If you experience sharp pain (not just muscle soreness), take an extra rest day or consult a healthcare provider.

Race Week Checklist

- ☐ Lay out all gear the night before
 - ☐ Check weather forecast
 - ☐ Review race course map
 - ☐ Plan parking and arrival time
 - ☐ Practice race-day breakfast
 - ☐ Get good sleep 2-3 nights before
 - ☐ Reduce training volume by 70%
 - ☐ Eat familiar foods only
 - ☐ Hydrate consistently
 - ☐ Arrive 30 minutes early on race day
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Remember: This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. You've got this! 🏃